restless and disrupted the game by throwing things onto the field. By then, however, the match was all over. Our World Cup dream lay shattered and there was a deathly silence in the dressing room.

This time the journey from the ground to the hotel was painful and when we reached the hotel we realized that everything had changed. We were made to feel as if we had done something seriously wrong. There was no doubt we had let our fans down, but we were hurting as much as anybody. It was a long and difficult night as we sat around picking over the way the match had played out.

We left Kolkata by the first available flight the following morning and I still found it difficult to accept that Sri Lanka and not India would be travelling to Pakistan to play in the World Cup final against Australia. We had done so well to win the quarter-final against Pakistan, the high point of our World Cup. Personally, I had had a good tournament and ended up with the most runs in the competition – 523, with two centuries and three half-centuries – but that was of little consolation. Our biggest mistake was misreading the Eden Gardens pitch. That is what cost us the game.

Indian cricket was not going through a good phase. With the World Cup dream over, team morale was low and we had little time to recover before a difficult tour of England, which we lost 1–0, though we did discover two superb talents in Rahul Dravid and Sourav Ganguly along the way. Though I scored a couple of centuries in this series, at Edgbaston and Trent Bridge, and Sourav scored two consecutive hundreds, on debut at Lord’s and at Trent Bridge, we weren’t able to make our way back after losing the first of the three Tests. The England bowlers, led by Chris Lewis, Dominic Cork and Alan Mullally, did well throughout the series and run-scoring was never easy. Nasser Hussain, the England skipper, also had a good series, leading from the front all the way.

Off the pitch, one incident from this tour is difficult to forget. Sourav Ganguly and Navjot Sidhu were travelling on the Tube in London when a few young guys, who’d probably had a bit too much to drink, boarded the train. For some reason they started making gestures at Sourav and Navjot and eventually one of them threw a beer can at Navjot, who promptly stood up to confront them. It turned ugly and a fight ensued, until the train reached the next station, where their attackers staggered off – but then one of them came back onto the train and started waving a